

He insisted the savings to be had with coupons was an illusion. “While some consumers can possibly save money at the expense of higher food prices and other consumers through the use of coupons, it is unlikely that coupons provide any net saving to consumers as a class,” he said, and then went on to state, “Since coupon usage does not require talent and has no productive value to the economy, the time and energy costs of coupon savings are a deadweight economic loss. Consumers are being ‘paid’ to perform tasks which merely redistribute income without producing anything of value. In the coupon game, consumers seem to be donating their time and energy costs in service to the coupon sponsors. Presumably, consumers have better, more productive uses of their time and talents.”

No talent? No productive value? Thousands of extreme couponers would disagree. Aren’t they the smartest of all shoppers? In fact, some of us are practically geniuses in the art of coupon savings. When a couponer walks out the door of a store with a cartload of free merchandise, they experience what many describe as a natural “high.” But according to detractors like Esther Peterson and J. N. Uhl, not only are couponers delusional, but their hobby is increasing prices and a complete waste of our time.

Jane Kolondinsky, an avid couponer and a Professor of the Department of Community Development and Applied Economics at the University of Vermont, studied whether or not the use of coupons was a worthwhile practice for consumers in terms of cost-effectiveness. Published in the *Journal of Consumer Studies and Home Economics* in 1992, she found that a full 40 percent of coupon clippers were not using coupons in a cost-effective manner. That percentage of coupon users studied did not reap